SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #44 · SALVATION

“I must suffer in purgatory before I can be with God.”

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Where it often comes from

Teaching about purgatory from childhood. Fear of suffering after death for sins you have not fully made up for. Pictures of punishment that made death frightening. Grief and worry about loved ones who have died. Christian traditions differ on this teaching; this card focuses on the fear that Christ’s work is not enough to bring you to God.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture points believers to the complete sufficiency of Christ. By a single offering He has made perfect for all time those who are being sanctified. After He provided purification for sins, He sat down, because the work was finished. To the thief on the cross, Jesus promised, “Today you will be with Me in Paradise.” Paul expected that to be away from the body is to be at home with the Lord. You can face death with hope, trusting what Christ has done.

> *“And Jesus said to him, ‘Truly I tell you, today you will be with Me in Paradise.’”* **(Luke 23:43)**.

Also see

> “Because by a single offering He has made perfect for all time those who are being sanctified” **(Hebrews 10:14)**.

> “The Son is the radiance of God’s glory and the exact representation of His nature, upholding all things by His powerful word. After He had provided purification for sins, He sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high” **(Hebrews 1:3)**.

> “Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus” **(Romans 8:1)**.

> “We are confident, then, and would prefer to be away from the body and at home with the Lord” **(2 Corinthians 5:8)**.

Common self-statements

- I’ll have to suffer a long time before I see God.
- My sins aren’t fully paid for yet.
- I’m terrified of what happens after I die.
- I have to suffer more now to shorten it later.
- My loved one is suffering because of me.
- Christ’s death covered some of my sins, but not all.

Common logical errors

- **Catastrophizing:** Picturing the worst possible suffering after death.
- **Discounting Christ’s work:** Believing His sacrifice was not enough.
- **Fear-based thinking:** Letting fear of the future rob your present peace.
- **Emotional reasoning:** Concluding “I feel unworthy, so I must be punished.”

Challenging questions

- What did Jesus promise the thief on the cross, who had no time to make up for anything?
- What does Hebrews 10:14 say Christ’s one offering accomplished?

- Why did Jesus sit down after purifying sins?
- Is there any condemnation for those in Christ Jesus?
- Where did Paul expect to be when he died?
- Am I trusting Christ's work, or adding my own?
- What would change if I faced death with hope?

Truth summary

> I do not have to fear suffering after death to pay for my sins. Christ's one offering has made me perfect forever in God's sight. There is no condemnation for me in Christ Jesus. When I die, I will be at home with the Lord. I can face death with hope because Jesus finished the work.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Death/Dying
- Christ, Sacrifice of
- Heaven
- Eternal Life
- Fear

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> **Overcoming Anxiety** · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

In Christ Alone — Keith & Kristyn Getty, CityAlight
Says Christ took the punishment for sin, so nothing is left for me to pay.

Death Was Arrested — North Point InsideOut
Celebrates that Christ's work has defeated death and set me free.

Christ Is Risen — Matt Maher
Proclaims that Christ is risen and has beaten death, so the believer need not fear it.

Because He Lives (Amen) — Matt Maher
Because Christ lives, I can face tomorrow and even death without fear.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I must suffer in purgatory before I can be with God"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I must suffer in purgatory before I can be with God." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What did Jesus promise the thief on the cross?
- ☐ What did Christ's one offering accomplish?
- ☐ Why did Jesus sit down?
- ☐ Is there condemnation for me in Christ?
- ☐ Where did Paul expect to be after death?
- ☐ Am I trusting Christ's work or adding my own?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Christ's one offering has made me perfect forever.
- ☐ There is no condemnation for me in Christ Jesus.
- ☐ To be away from the body is to be at home with the Lord.
- ☐ Jesus finished the work of purifying my sins.
- ☐ I can face death with hope.
- ☐ My salvation rests on Christ, not on my suffering.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Luke 23:43**
  "And Jesus said to him, 'Truly I tell you, today you will be with Me in Paradise.'"
- [ ] **Hebrews 10:14**
  "Because by a single offering He has made perfect for all time those who are being sanctified."
- [ ] **Hebrews 1:3**
  "The Son is the radiance of God's glory and the exact representation of His nature, upholding all things by His powerful word. After He had provided purification for sins, He sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high."
- [ ] **Romans 8:1**
  "Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus."
- [ ] **2 Corinthians 5:8**
  "We are confident, then, and would prefer to be away from the body and at home with the Lord."

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Listen to one song each day** from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Hope journal:** Each day, write one thing I look forward to about being with the Lord.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Luke 23:43 becomes: "And Jesus said to **Sarah**, 'Truly I tell you, today you will be with Me in Paradise.'"*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Heaven" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Read Luke 23:39–43,** and write what the thief did and what Jesus promised him.
- ☐ **Read Hebrews 10:10–18,** and underline every word that says Christ's work is complete.
- ☐ **Talk with your pastor or priest** about your fears of death and what your church teaches.
- ☐ **When fear of death comes, pray:** "Jesus, my hope is in You," and read Romans 8:1.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I must suffer in purgatory before I can be with God": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One thing I look forward to
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I must suffer in purgatory before I can be with God.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord Jesus, thank You that You finished the work of purifying my sins. Help me reject the fear that I must suffer before I can be with You. Thank You that there is no condemnation for me in You, and that to be away from the body is to be at home with You. Give me hope as I think about the future. In Your name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.